

Western Religious traditions

Lecture #1

background

World Religions.

Neolithic religion: pastoralists and planters

the paleolithic culture covered approximately 1 million years which is followed by the mesolithic or old stone age culture.

neolithic culture (new stone age) began at different times in different places. The neolithic period marks the transition from food-gathering and hunter societies to food-producing societies.

in the middle east, the neolithic period began about 5000 B.C. E and ended with the beginning of the bronze age about 3000 B.C.E. in Denmark the neolithic period covers the time 2500 B to 1500 B. and in Australia the aborigines have never begun the neolithic age.

In the Neolithic age the skills of domesticating animals, cultivating farmland, weaving cloth, and making pottery were developed.

this led to the emergence of two new kinds of society: pastoral and agricultural ones.

pastoral societies tend to be "Uranian", that is the prime religious symbol is the sky, which is the abode of the gods.

These societies view power of their deities in the sky, sun, thunder, and storm which are the forces which herders are much concerned about.

These societies and their gods are usually patriarchal.

This pattern is found in many early civilizations.

Greek Zeus and Roman Jupiter, the Semitic (Hebrew) YHWH, Indra and Varuna of the Aryans, Thor of the Scandinavians are examples of "High Gods" of the sky related to pastoral religion.

agricultural or planter religions tend to stress the recurring cycles of springtime and harvest, of the regenerative and reproductive powers of nature.

The prime symbol is the Earth, not the sky. The feminine rather than the masculine.

The basic concern is with birth, fertility, growth, maturation. Here a goddess often assumes preeminence

The

god.

In various ways agricultural religions have oriented themselves toward symbols of a **great** goddess--"mother of wheat", or "Mother of Maize".

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In later religions the Great Mother appears as the Greek Hecate and Persephone, the Roman Cybele the Indian Kali. She is Inanna in the Sumerians, Isis to the Egyptians, and Mary to the Assyrians and Babylonians, to the Christians.

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A key image in agricultural religion is **the** seed which dies in the earth, only to come to life again as a burgeoning crop.

The pattern of death and rebirth in endless alternation, **just** as the life of summer always follows the death of winter, is celebrated in myth and ritual.

Human and animal sacrifice played a significant role at times in agricultural religion. In order to influence, encourage, and participate in life processes that are fertile and bounteous, agricultural communities sometimes made ritual offerings of human beings, whose death was believed to release the powers of life and fertility in the community.

The patterns of agricultural religion later merged with those of archaic civilizations.

In

Mesopotamia and Egypt

civilization is not a synonym for culture. a culture is the totality of learned, socially transmitted behaviour present in a human society. Thus, by definition, every society has a culture.

"civilization" refers to a certain kind of social and cultural organization that emerged in the Near East around two basic characteristics of civil

ons are the use

of writing and the greater differentiation of the parts of the social complex when compared to a primitive society.

Enlil, head of the pantheon who was the beneficent and fatherly creator of sun, moon, vegetation and implements essential to human control.

Enki and Ninke (lord and lady of the earth) are in some myths said to be the parents of Enlil.

Dumuzi is a hero who later assumes the role of a fertility god, representing the dying and reviving vegetation. He **was**, according to myth, the consort of Inanna, the love goddess, who sends him to the region of the dead to abide there in her place.

With the Assyrians and Babylonians,

Inanna is called

Ishtar or Astarte, and Dumuzi is Tammuz mentioned in the Bible in Ezek. 8:14 with the women weeping for him.

When the Babylonians became powerful the god Marduk assumes the role of the highest god.

in the document from that period called the Enuma Elish the epic of creation is given in which Marduk defeats the dragon Tiamut and her consort Apsu and creates the world from her body, including humans. Thus he is the controller of the destiny of the world, he founds Babylon and its temple and becomes its national god.

this is an excellent example of a myth of transition when one civilization overwhelms another and replaces its gods with their own.

the myth of Adam and Eve is another such myth in which the symbols sacred to the fertility religion of the Canaanites (the fig tree, the serpent) are shown to be the cause of the fall of humans into sin.

The creation myth is connected with certain ritual ceremonies in which agricultural and political myths are combined.

thus the Babylonian king begins his reign on New Year's day in the month of Nisan at the time of the spring rains.

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Marduk.

This ceremony was correlated with other symbolic acts acknowledging the threat of chaos.

the Enuma Elish was read and ritual enactment of Markuk's victory over Tiamat was performed.

evidently at the end of this sacred festival, the king and queen OF a selected priestess engaged in ritual intercourse symbolizing the union of Ishtar and Tammuz, which ensured the continued fertility of the earth.

· These civilizations of the Near East were centered in the idea of kingship.

the king was the mediating point that joined the world of the gods and the world of human society into a single dynamic interacting process.

Thru the agency of the king, human society functioned according to the norms and patterned decreed by the gods and which the gods also exemplified in their relations to one another.

The king in Mesopotamia was expected to deal justly and without favor, to defend the weak against the strong and to take the part of the fatherless and of the widow.

thus, the political patterns in human society reflected the pattern of authority that also operated among the gods themselves.

There is an important difference between Mesopotamians and Egypt in the idea of kingship

In Mesopotamia the king was the agent of the gods and ruled in their name but he himself was human and subject to

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death

the famous epic of Gilgamesh, a great king tells of the search for eternal life that even he cannot obtain. The myth shows the essential finitude of man, even the king. only the gods are immortal.

Egypt on the other hand, has the Pharaoh himself regarded as one of the gods who had descended among men.

In the Egyptian scheme, the social order, thru the authority of the divine pharaoh, has itself been divinized.

The Egyptian pantheon of gods included Horus depicted in human shape with a falcon's head. He was the god of political authority and the pharaoh was sometimes regarded as the kingly incarnation of Horus on earth.

the cult of Isis and Osiris

In the myth, Osiris is killed by his brother Seth. Isis his sister/wife mourns him and thru magic spells gets herself impergnated by her dead husband.

She gives birth to Horus to whom the gods give the rights and dignity originally belonging to his father. .

Osiris is then restored to life and made sovereign over the realm of the dead.

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The vigor of egyptian belief in life after death empowered the Egyptian religion to persist in

to persist in some form as

late as the sixth cent. A.D. in the cult of Isis and Osiris.

The Egyptian pharaoh Amenhotep IV (Akhenaten) tried to institute a monotheistic cult centered on the worship of the sun disk under the name of Aton. it was short lived and destroyed by the Egyptian priests on his death. This is where the curs2 on the tomb of Tutankamen originates as he was the son of Akhenaten.

Greek Religion

Greek religion is the product of a fusion of the cults of a native population, the Pelasgians, with those of northern invaders (Aryans).

behind the pantheon of gods with which most are familiar are rituals and practices tied in with tribal patterns of thought and behavior.

Homer, author of the Iliad and the Odyssey seems to be responsible for the formalization of the various ritual beliefs into a systematic pantheon of gods in which each divinity possesses a distinctive indivduality.

The pantheon which emerged during the classical period included Zeus, the sky god, Hera his wife: Ares, god of war; goc or fire and or the satny, Fallas Athena goddess of wi dom who guided Athens: Apolle the SUR 900 Of Music. he is the exemplar of Calin, clear light.

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The Olympian gods comprise the uranian (pastoral) element in Greek religion which is dominant during the classical period.

This was brought in by the Aryan invaders and the pantheon has equivalents in India which the Aryans brought in there.

However, there are other important elements.

first, the cult of the Chthonoi, spirits who live in the
They are connected with

dark recesses of the earth.

fertility and death. These spirits have the qualities of demons, hobgoblins, gods of the night, darkness, terror, and death.

they are not evil in the absolute sense but represent the darker passions and **fears** of humans contrasted with his aspiration after light, clarity and freedom.

the other non-Olympian element in Greek religion is the presence of various "mystery religions" Don't know if they are indigenous to Greece or brought in from Asia Minor.

Three are important: Orphism, the Dionysian cult and the Eleusinian mysteries.

The Eleusinian mysteries celebrate the story of Demeter and her daughter Kore, who was abducted by Hades, god of the dead, and taken to his realm.

Demeter bore for all

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Mother of all

morning and

I not allow the agricultural

realm

rejuvenate itself

Zeus convinced Hades to give up Kore but while there she had eaten a pomegranate seed and thus had to return to Hades each year.

Winter and summer were the seasons of her descent and return.

The rites of this cult enabled the members to feel they were participating in the divine events proclaimed in the myth. This was a nine day ceremony and was the "thing to do" in the ancient world.

the cult of Dionysus still present in the Mardi Gras,,

cultivated frenzied and orgiastic emotions and dances and is often contrasted with the calm and clarity of Apollo.

He was the son of Zeus, born from his father's body when his mother died before giving him birth.

The Orphic cult has a similar story to tell about Orpheus but is mainly concerned with Orpheus search for his love in the land of the dead.

These mystery cults promised the initiate access to a kind of immortality not available to the outsider.

Other cults that influenced Mediterranean cultures include the mysteries of the Phrygian Cybele and Attis (made the official religion of Rome by Claudius in 51 A.D.) and the cult of Isis and Osiris. In the second cent. the cult

the Persian 11 ant-gcc Mishra: was popular. 2. day on Dec

The important feature of these cults is they revealed a growing independence from their original culture.

Most of

the mystery cults are not tied to a specific tribe, or

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nation, but form universal societies composed of members from a variety of places.

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Religions of Roman civilization

The religious practices of the ancient Romans were centered around the family and civic life.

thru symbol and rite a respect was paid to the numinous powers and forces believed to be present in natural phenomena and in hearth and home. Otto coined the term "numinous" to characterize the feeling of religious awe OR the basis of this Roman usage.

Later the numina, which at first were felt as vague forces in archaic symbols and rituals, took on more specific forms in the familiar pantheon of Roman gods which were in many instances patterned after Greek models.

Thus Jupiter is the sky god; Juno, his consort; Diane, the moon goddess; Neptune, the sea god; Mars, the war god. as the Roman empire emerged in the first century its approach to religion changed. it created a cosmopolitan approach a philosophers noted similarities

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skepticism about the truth of any religious system. thus many romans of the period treated the gods a poetical expressions

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not as matters of conviction.

the other attitude was the attempt of some philosophers to create a syncretistic comprehensive religious system in which gods form a number of different cultures are included. the Emperor Julian attempted w/o success to impose such a system as the official religion of the empire as a whole.

One Roman philosopher, Varo, summerized the forms under three headings:

mythological religion.

represented by the gods referred to in the writings of poets and sometimes worshiped by numerous groups of the populace;

Civic religion, represneted by those rites that maintained loyalty to the Roman state; and

natural religion, represented by the speculations of philosophers like the Platonists and the Stoics.

The Romans had to develop a sense of loyalty to Roman authority to control its empire. thus, rites of obeisance to the emperor as adivine personage were instituted as a supplement to other existing religios practices. This resulted from a pragmatic desire to acheive political unity.

In 312 C.E. the Roman empire adopted Christianity as the izgion.

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spoke of Zoroastrian belief in lectures on India so will cover others.

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Mithraism

Mithra was originally an Aryan god and was worshipped in Iran as the god of contracts. He preserves truth and order, destroying the disruptive forces of evil, anger, greed, prride and procrastination, all evil gods and men.

as guardian of contracts, he determines when the period of the devil's rule will end and as guardian of truth, is the judge of the soul at death. His coming amid the homage of the meek and lowly in days of victory is awaited.

some christian writers mention an Oracle which fortells

the god's coming at the end of the world to destroy the wicked with fire and to save the righteous.

many Roman monuments depict his birth and some 5th cent. Christian texts imply there was a Mithraic myth foretelling the appearance of a star which would lead magi to the birthplace of Jesus.

Mithra is an important and popular deity and still occupies an important place in Zoroastrian ritual.

His cult was popular east to India and west to Asia Minor.

Mithraism first entered Rome in 50 B. and in the 2nd cent

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a male cult carried by soldiers.

Baptism WAE

It was

Silent for entrance

had to submit to both physical and spiritual effects to adhere to a strict moral code.

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He was

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in return he was

promised a share in the resurrection.

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The central belief of the cult was the sacrifice of a bull by Mithras. This act was both creative and redemptive. The worshipper looked back to a sacrifice at the beginning, when life had come out of death, and forward to the final sacrifice by Mithras when the last animal to die would give men the elixir of immortality. A foretaste of this gift could be shared in the regular communion meal of bread and wine in which the priest represented Mithra.

The Mandeans

or Nazoreans,

are a small sect still in existence in southern Iraq and neighbouring Iran. claim descent from John the Baptist and believe their ancestors fled with the fall of Jerusalem in 70 A.

they are a mixture of Semitic, Iranian elements and much Gnostic content.

They use no anthropomorphic language but call God things like "king of light" "Lord of greatness"

the world is
created by emanations from the King of light, one of the
most important of these being the saviour, Manda d'Hayye (the
knowledge of Life, whence the name of the sect.

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religions which inhibit the release of the soul

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the planets, stars and material world.

Baptism wards off evil spirits and is essential to
salvation.

a ritual meal is associated with it and ritual
is very important and must be done properly or dire
consequences ensue. Asceticism is not practiced and is not
considered a way to free the soul.

plague in the 19th cent. killed virtually all the priests
tho a new hierarchy was formed, no new replacements
seem to be coming.

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Influence of Iranian religion

the influence on Islam has been such as to help it
develop from an Arabian into an international religion; the
growth of the mystical movement, the Sufis, and the saviour
concept may owe something to Iranian influence.

Iran's greatest influence has been on the development of
Judaean-Christian belief. It is widely accepted by biblical
scholars that the later Jewish concepts of the devil, hell,
an afterlife, the resurrection, and the end of the world and
the saviour imagery were all coloured by Zoroastrianism and
Mithraism. These beliefs have affected the very foundations
of Judaism and particularly Christianity.